

ARABIAN HIGHLANDS

A moisture-laden haven for wildlife and plant species

The Arabian Highlands are a collection of mountain ranges, ridges, and plateaus rising around the fringes of the Arabian Peninsula. They stretch inland from the coastal “fog desert” and surround the Empty Quarter, the peninsula’s vast sandy desert. Due to their altitude, the highlands are cooler and damper than the nearby deserts and are able to support a greater diversity of plant and animal life. Moisture-laden oceanic winds are forced up and over the mountains, producing seasonal rainfall, and low nighttime temperatures cause fog and dew formation.

Vital juniper woodland

Unusually, it is the highest areas of this ecoregion that are covered with woodland. Here juniper trees are particularly abundant and provide vital cover and food for several bird species. Drier, south-facing slopes are home to more succulent plants, such as aloe and euphorbia,

while the foothills are covered with shrubland and savanna. Many of the area’s plant and bird species are found nowhere else in the world, but the peninsula also serves as an important land bridge between Africa and Eurasia for migrating birds, many of which follow the ridge of the Asir Mountains that run parallel to the Red Sea coast. In terms of mammal species, the Arabian Highlands are home to several large carnivores, including the caracal, the rare Arabian wolf, and the striped hyena. They also form one of the last strongholds of the critically endangered Arabian leopard.



SPIKY SUCCULENT

Reaching up to 33 ft (10 m) in height, *Euphorbia ammak* resembles a cactus, but is actually a succulent tree-like plant from the spurge family. Its thick, spiny stems contain an unpleasant-tasting sap that discourages herbivores from browsing on it.

EUPHORBIA AMMAK

Home to more than 2,000 plant species

The slender mountain gazelle lives throughout the Arabian Highlands, especially where acacia is found. As well as leaves and seed pods, it eats succulent plants and digs for bulbs and corns, especially when water is scarce.

ACACIA EATER



MOUNTAIN GAZELLE

41 reptile species live here

CLIMBING SERPENT

The Arabian cat snake is an agile, stealthy predator, able to climb trees and rock faces in search of prey such as rodents, lizards, fledgling birds, and bats. This nocturnal species kills with its venomous fangs and is widespread in the region.

ARABIAN CAT SNAKE

Arabian oryx

